

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1993-08-15

To an individual bahá'í

dear bahá'í friend,

expressing your concern over the wearing of long hair and earrings by some of the students of the . . . School, and conveying your view that the School

should enforce bahá'í standards as a condition for enrollment. we have been instructed to send you the following reply.^{164.5}

164.6

165.1

message from The Universal House of Justice

As you are aware, the blessed perfection himself advised that the utmost wisdom should be exercised in applying the Sacred laws, and it is only gradually that these have been enforced in the bahá'í community. indeed, as the beloved guardian stated, certain of the laws are designed for a future state of society.

The law of the Aqdas that, in the case of men, “. . . it is not seemly to let the hair pass beyond the limit of the ears”¹⁶⁵⁻¹ has not yet been universally applied. bahá'u'lláh's statement is in the most holy book for all to read, but its application should be left to the discretion of each individual. it is not fitting at this time for either bahá'í institutions or individual believers to make an issue of this matter or attempt to enforce it on other believers. As for the wearing of earrings, nothing at all has been found in the holy Texts on this matter beyond the general counsel given by bahá'u'lláh in paragraph 159 of the Aqdas, namely:

The lord hath relieved you, as a bounty on his part, of the restrictions that formerly applied to clothing and to the trim of the beard.

he, verily, is the ordainer, the omniscient. let there be naught in your demeanor of which sound and upright minds would disapprove, and make not yourselves the playthings of the ignorant. well is it with

him who hath adorned himself with the vesture of seemly conduct and a praiseworthy character. he is assuredly reckoned with those who aid their lord through distinctive and outstanding deeds.

it is, of course, within the discretion of an institution such as a school to lay down codes of dress and behavior for its pupils. in this it must show good judgment in the light of bahá'í principles and in the context of the culture in which it operates.

if you wish to convey your recommendations to the . . . School you are, of course, entirely free to do so.

with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

165-1. kA, ¶43.165.2

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165.4a

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1993–1996 • The Three Year Plan

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Preservation of Original Sacred Text

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]